PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #77 · SUBSTANCE ABUSE

"Other people are the reason I use. If they treated me better, I wouldn't need it."

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Other people really can be part of the story. Stress, cruelty, loneliness, a house that was never safe, a loss someone else caused: those things hurt, and using may have been how you got through them. The lie goes one step further. It says you have no next step until they treat you better, and that the using is simply their fault. Their harm can be real and still not be the only thing that gets to decide your tomorrow. You can grieve what they did and still reach for help. You do not have to pretend you caused their treatment in order to get care for yourself. If you want help, call the SAMHSA National Helpline at 1-800-662-4357. Do not try to stop or withdraw on your own if that could make you sick. A doctor can help you do it safely, and a counselor can walk with you. Needing that help is not a failure.

What Scripture teaches

Help comes from the Lord, the Maker of heaven and earth. That help is not postponed until the people who hurt you apologize. He is near the brokenhearted, which includes hearts broken by other people. Jesus invites the weary. You can approach Him for grace to help in time of need. He will strengthen you. These verses do not deny that people wounded you. They say your help does not have to wait on their change.

> *"I lift up my eyes to the hills. From where does my help come? My help comes from the LORD, the Maker of heaven and earth"* (Psalm 121:1–2).

Also see

> "The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit" (Psalm 34:18).

> "Come to Me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest" (Matthew 11:28).

> "Let us then approach the throne of grace with confidence, so that we may receive mercy and find grace to help us in our time of need" (Hebrews 4:16).

> "Do not fear, for I am with you; do not be afraid, for I am your God. I will strengthen you; I will surely help you; I will uphold you with My right hand of righteousness" (Isaiah 41:10).

Common self-statements

- If they were kinder, I would not use.
- This is on them, so I do not have to look at it.
- Nothing will change until they change.
- Getting help means I am letting them off the hook.
- I am only doing what they drove me to.
- God should fix them first.

Common logical errors

- Blame shifting: Making another person's wrong the reason you cannot take any step.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Either they change or you have no choices at all.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling powerless around them and deciding you are powerless everywhere.
- Fortune telling: Deciding you will use for as long as they stay the same.

Challenging questions

- What did they actually do, and what have I added by saying I have no choice?
- Can their wrong be real and my next step still be mine?
- What help is available even if they never apologize?
- Who is a safe person who is not the person I am blaming?
- What would I want for a friend in this exact spot?
- Where does my help come from if it does not come from their reform?

Truth summary

> People have hurt me, and that is real. Their treatment does not remove my next step. I can get help even if they do not change.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

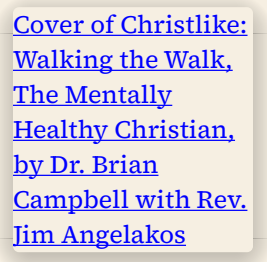
- Guilt/Shame
- Thinking, Healthy
- Help
- Forgiveness
- Suffering

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Suffering
- Thinking, Healthy
- Love

What does a mentally healthy Christian look like?



From *Christlike: Walking the Walk* by Dr. Brian Campbell. A portrait, verse by verse, of how a mentally healthy Christian thinks, feels, and lives.

Read excerpts from "The Mentally Healthy Christian" (with every Scripture written out)

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Jesus — Chris Tomlin
Jesus stays with you in the hurt other people caused. He also stays for the next step.

What You Want — Tenth Avenue North
You can want a different way even if the people who hurt you do not change.

I Am Not Alone — Kari Jobe
You are not alone with their treatment or with the choice in front of you.

What a Friend We Have in Jesus — Keith and Kristyn Getty
You can tell God what they did and still ask for help with what you do next.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, what is one step I could take today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Other people are the reason I use. If they treated me better, I wouldn't need it."

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Other people are the reason I use. If they treated me better, I wouldn't need it." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What did they actually do, and what have I added by saying I have no choice?
- ☐ Can their wrong be real and my next step still be mine?
- ☐ What help is available even if they never apologize?
- ☐ Who is a safe person who is not the person I am blaming?
- ☐ What would I want for a friend in this exact spot?
- ☐ Where does my help come from if it does not come from their reform?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ People have hurt me, and that is real. Their treatment does not remove my next step. I can get help even if they do not change.
- ☐ What other people did can be truly wrong.
- ☐ I do not have to excuse them in order to get help.
- ☐ I also do not have to wait for them before I ask for help.
- ☐ God's help is not on their timetable.
- ☐ A counselor can help me hold both truths.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Psalm 121:1–2
  "I lift up my eyes to the hills. From where does my help come? My help comes from the LORD, the Maker of heaven and earth."
- ☐ Psalm 34:18
  "The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit."
- ☐ Matthew 11:28
  "Come to Me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest."

A verse I found myself:

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] When you gave them the whole reason: Each day, write down one moment when someone else's treatment felt like the reason you had to use. Write what happened, what you told yourself, and one more accurate statement.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Psalm 121:2 becomes: "James can write: "My help comes from the Lord. I do not have to wait for them to change.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Suffering" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio or the Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If this belief comes with hopelessness or thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. For help with substance use, call 1-800-662-4357, and talk with a doctor before you stop if withdrawal could make you sick.

- [ ] Write two lines. "What they did" and "the step I can take anyway." Do not use the second line to excuse the first.
- [ ] Tell a helper who is not the person you blame. A counselor, a doctor, or 1-800-662-4357.
- [ ] Ask a doctor before you change how you stop. Do not make a sudden stop your way of proving them wrong.
- [ ] Pray Psalm 121:1–2 when you want to wait for them to become kinder.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Other people are the reason I use. If they treated me better, I wouldn't need it.": _____ %

My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A step I took without waiting for them
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Other people are the reason I use. If they treated me better, I wouldn't need it~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, people have hurt me, and I have used that as the whole reason. Be near the brokenhearted. Give me help that does not wait on their change. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.